490.LIFE · THE WHOLE STORY · LESSON 19 OF 26

Who Jesus Is

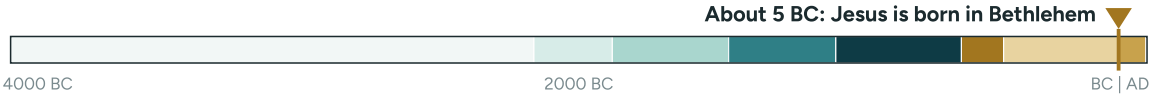
John 1; Luke 1–2; Mark 2; 4; Matthew 16–17



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YOU ARE HERE · LESSON 19



Introduction: The One the Whole Story Was Waiting For

For eighteen lessons we have followed a promise. In Eden, God promised that the offspring of the woman would crush the serpent's head (Lesson 4). He promised Abraham that all the nations would be blessed through his offspring (Lesson 6). He promised David a Son whose throne would last forever (Lesson 14). He promised a new covenant, a new heart, and a King whose kingdom would never end (Lesson 17). Then came four hundred years of silence.

This lesson opens Unit 5, "The King Arrives." Around 5 BC, in the little town of Bethlehem, a baby was born to a young woman named Mary. The whole Bible has been pointing to him. His name was Jesus.

This lesson asks the most important question anyone can ask: who is he? Not just what he taught, or what he did, but who he is. Jesus himself put the question to his closest friends: "But who do you say that I am?" (Matt. 16:15). By the end of this lesson, you will have to answer it too.

The Word: Immanuel

> **Matthew 1:22–23** *"All this took place to fulfill what the Lord had spoken by the prophet: 'Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a son, and they shall call his name Immanuel' (which means, God with us)."*

עִמָּנוּאֵל *(Immanu-el, "Immanuel")*

"God with us"

עִמָּנוּ (immanu)

"with us"

Near us, beside us, among us.

+

אֵל (El)

"God"

The same word for God we met in Elijah's name (Lesson 16).

Payoff: Isaiah spoke this name about seven hundred years before Jesus was born (Isa. 7:14). Matthew says it came true in him. Think about every thread of God dwelling with his people: Eden, the tabernacle, the temple, the glory that left and the promise that it would return. In Jesus, God did not send a cloud or fill a building. He came himself, as a real man, body and soul. God with us.

Part One: The Word Became Flesh

John begins his Gospel before the beginning of everything: "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God. He was in the beginning with God. All things were made through him" (John 1:1–3). The Word is not a thing. He is a Person, with God and yet himself God, the one through whom the universe was made. Then John says the most astonishing sentence in the Bible: "And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us" (1:14). The Creator took a created human nature to himself, without ever ceasing to be the Creator.

How did it happen? An angel told a young virgin in Nazareth named Mary that she would have a son. When she asked how, since she was a virgin, the angel answered, "The Holy Spirit will come upon you, and the power of the Most High will overshadow you; therefore the child to be born will be called holy," and then the angel named him: "the Son of God" (Luke 1:35). Jesus had a human mother but no human father. The eternal Son of God took a real human nature from Mary, in her womb, by the Holy Spirit.

He was born in Bethlehem, the town of David, just as the prophet Micah had said seven centuries earlier (Mic. 5:2). The Roman emperor Augustus had ordered a census, so Joseph and Mary traveled there from Nazareth, and Mary "gave birth to her firstborn son and wrapped him in swaddling cloths and laid him in a manger, because there was no place for them in the inn" (Luke 2:7). The King of the universe was laid in an animal's feeding trough.

The first people to hear the news were shepherds, working the night shift outside town. An angel told them, "For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord" (2:11). Notice the three titles. *Savior*: he came to rescue. *Christ*: the anointed King promised to David. *Lord*: in the Greek Old Testament, the word that stands for God's own name, the one your English Bible prints as LORD.

(A note on the date: the monk who set up our calendar about AD 525 miscalculated by a few years. Herod the Great, who was alive when Jesus was born, died around 4 BC, so Jesus was probably born around 6 to 4 BC.)

Part Two: Truly God

As Jesus grew up and began his public ministry around age thirty, he said and did things that made people ask, again and again, who he was.

He forgave sins. When friends lowered a paralyzed man through a roof, Jesus said, "Son, your sins are forgiven." The religious teachers were scandalized: "Who can forgive sins but God alone?" (Mark 2:5, 7). They were right about that. So Jesus healed the man on the spot, so that they would "know that the Son of Man has authority on earth to forgive sins" (2:10).

He ruled the wind and the sea. On the Sea of Galilee, a storm nearly swamped the disciples' boat while Jesus slept. They woke him in terror. "And he awoke and rebuked the wind and said to the sea, 'Peace! Be still!' And the wind ceased, and there was a great calm." The disciples were more frightened afterward

than during the storm: “Who then is this, that even the wind and the sea obey him?” (Mark 4:39, 41). In the Old Testament, it is God who rules the raging sea and stills its waves (Ps. 89:9; 107:29).



“Who then is this, that even the wind and the sea obey him?” (Mark 4:41).

He took God’s name. At the burning bush, God told Moses his name: “I am who I am” (Ex. 3:14; Lesson 2). One day Jesus told his opponents, “Truly, truly, I say to you, before Abraham was, I am” (John 8:58). They knew exactly what he meant. “So they picked up stones to throw at him” (8:59). Stoning was the Law’s punishment for blasphemy (Lev. 24:16). Later they said it plainly: “It is not for a good work that we are going to stone you but for blasphemy, because you, being a man, make yourself God” (John 10:33). He also said, “I and the Father are one” (10:30), and “Whoever has seen me has seen the Father” (14:9). This does not mean Jesus is the Father. The Father and the Son are two distinct persons who share the one being of God. That is why Jesus can be “with God” and “God” at the same time (John 1:1).

“I Am”: Jesus in the Gospel of John

God’s name at the burning bush: “I am who I am” (Ex. 3:14)

“I am the bread of life” *John 6:35*	**“I am the light of the world”** *John 8:12*
“I am the door” *John 10:9*	**“I am the good shepherd”** *John 10:11*
“I am the resurrection and the life” *John 11:25*	**“I am the way, and the truth, and the life”** *John 14:6*
“I am the true vine” *John 15:1*	**“Before Abraham was, I am”** *John 8:58*

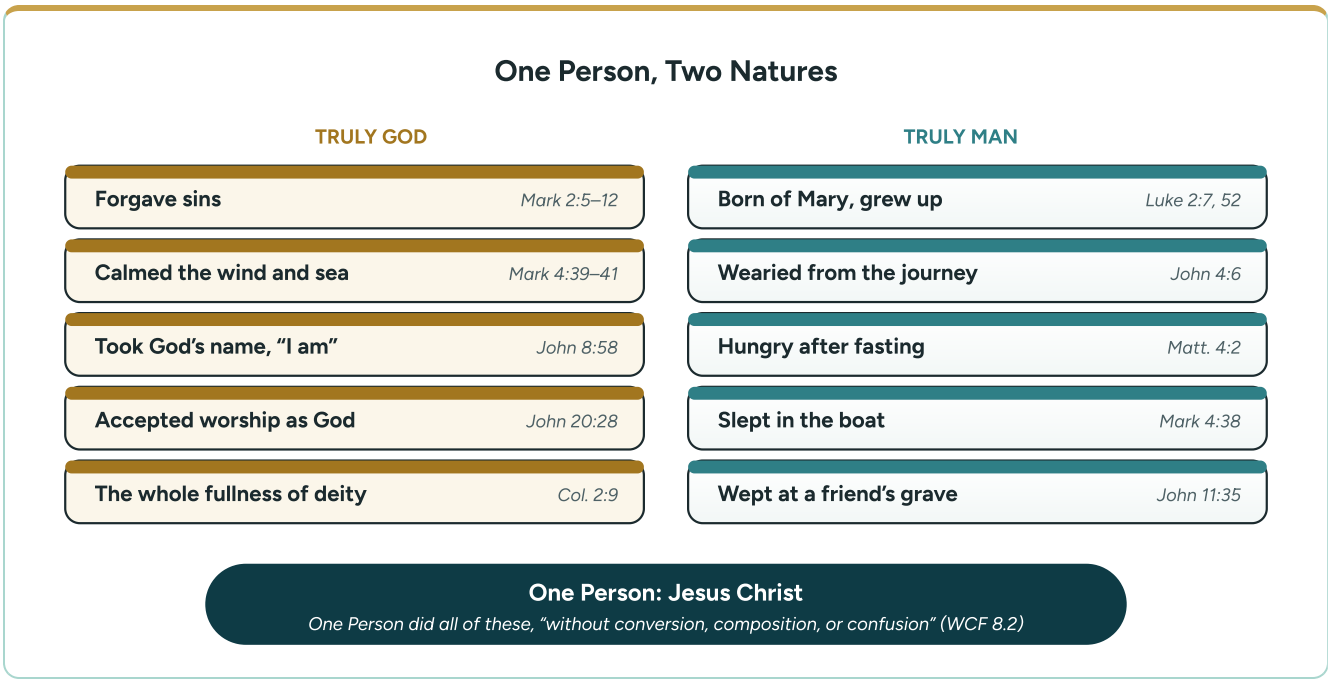
When Jesus said “before Abraham was, I am,” his hearers picked up stones (John 8:59).

He accepted worship. After the resurrection, the women who met him "took hold of his feet and worshiped him" (Matt. 28:9). The doubting disciple Thomas looked at him and confessed, "My Lord and my God!" (John 20:28). Jesus corrected none of them. Every faithful Jew knew that only God may be worshiped. Paul sums it up: "For in him the whole fullness of deity dwells bodily" (Col. 2:9). Jesus is not a great man who became divine, or an angel, or a lesser god. He is God the Son.

Part Three: Truly Man

But the same Gospels that show Jesus' divine glory show his full humanity just as clearly. He was a baby who needed his mother. He "increased in wisdom and in stature and in favor with God and man" (Luke 2:52). He got tired: "Jesus, wearied as he was from his journey, was sitting beside the well" (John 4:6). He got hungry (Matt. 4:2). He fell asleep in a boat (Mark 4:38). At the grave of his friend Lazarus, Jesus wept. In most English Bibles it is the shortest verse of all: "Jesus wept" (John 11:35). He was tempted in every way we are, "yet without sin" (Heb. 4:15).

Christians have always confessed both truths together. Jesus is one Person with two natures, fully God and fully man. The Westminster Confession puts it carefully: the two natures were joined together in one person, "without conversion, composition, or confusion" (WCF 8.2). He did not stop being God when he became man. He did not become a mix of the two. He is truly God and truly man, forever.



Why does it matter? Because only someone who is both could save us. He had to be truly man to stand in our place, obey where we disobeyed, and die our death. "Therefore he had to be made like his brothers in every respect, so that he might become a merciful and faithful high priest in the service of God, to make propitiation for the sins of the people" (Heb. 2:17). "For there is one God, and there is one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus" (1 Tim. 2:5). And he had to be truly God for his obedience

and death to have infinite worth and to conquer death. Paul describes how far he came down: though he was "in the form of God," he "emptied himself, by taking the form of a servant… he humbled himself by becoming obedient to the point of death, even death on a cross" (Phil. 2:6–8). He did not empty himself of being God. He emptied himself by taking: he added a servant's nature to the divine nature he always had, and he set aside the glory and honor that were his right.

CORE DOCTRINE 19 OF 26

Jesus: Truly God and Truly Man

Jesus Christ is one person with two natures. He is fully God, the eternal Son, and fully man, with a real body and soul. The two natures are not mixed or divided. He became one of us without ceasing to be God, so that he could stand in our place.

KEY VERSES

John 1:1, 14; Colossians 2:9; Hebrews 2:14–17; Philippians 2:5–8

WHAT THE CHURCH CONFESSES

"The only Redeemer of God's elect is the Lord Jesus Christ, who, being the eternal Son of God, became man, and so was, and continueth to be, God and man in two distinct natures, and one person, for ever." (Westminster Shorter Catechism 21)

THE TRINITY HERE

The Son did not begin at Bethlehem. He is the eternal second person of the Trinity, who took on our flesh.

WHY IT MATTERS

Only God could save us, and only a man could die in our place. Jesus is both.

Part Four: Who Do You Say I Am?

At a turning point in his ministry, Jesus took his disciples north to Caesarea Philippi and asked them what people were saying about him. Some said John the Baptist, others Elijah, Jeremiah, or one of the prophets. Then he made it personal: "But who do you say that I am?" Simon Peter answered, "You are the Christ, the Son of the living God." And Jesus said, "Blessed are you, Simon Bar-Jonah! For flesh and blood has not revealed this to you, but my Father who is in heaven" (Matt. 16:15–17). To see who Jesus really is takes a gift from God.

Six days later, Jesus took Peter, James, and John up a high mountain. There "he was transfigured before them, and his face shone like the sun, and his clothes became white as light. And behold, there appeared to them Moses and Elijah, talking with him" (17:2–3). The Law and the Prophets stood beside the One they had pointed to. Then a bright cloud overshadowed them, the same word the angel used to Mary, and a voice from the cloud said, "This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased; listen to him" (17:5). The disciples fell on their faces. And Jesus touched them and said, "Rise, and have no fear" (17:7).



"This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased; listen to him" (Matt. 17:5).

Jesus also said plainly why he came: "For the Son of Man came to seek and to save the lost" (Luke 19:10). "For even the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many" (Mark 10:45). Lesson 20 will listen to what he taught about his kingdom. Lessons 21 and 22 will follow him to the cross and out of the tomb. But first, the question must be answered.

THREAD WATCH

THE LAMB When John the Baptist saw Jesus coming toward him, he said, "Behold, the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world!" (John 1:29). Every lamb in the story pointed to him: the ram on Moriah, the Passover lamb, the lambs on the altar, and the lamb led to the slaughter in Isaiah 53.

GOD WITH HIS PEOPLE The word John uses for "dwelt" in John 1:14 means "pitched his tent" (Lesson 10). The God who lived in a tent in the wilderness and filled the temple with his glory now lived among his people as a real man. "And we have seen his glory." Immanuel, God with us.

The Turn: The Question That Will Not Go Away

The whole Old Testament was waiting for three kinds of leader. It needed a Prophet who would speak God's final word, a Priest who would offer a sacrifice that really takes sin away, and a King from David's line who would reign forever. Jesus is all three in one Person (Westminster Shorter Catechism 23). As Paul says, "all the promises of God find their Yes in him" (2 Cor. 1:20).

Many people today say Jesus was a good teacher and nothing more. But a merely good teacher does not forgive other people's sins, claim God's name, accept worship, and say that seeing him is seeing God. Either those claims are false, or he is exactly who he said he is. Peter and Thomas reached their

conclusion. John wrote his whole Gospel so that you could reach it too: "these are written so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name" (John 20:31).

So the question comes to you: who do you say that he is? If you are not sure yet, keep reading the Gospels, and ask God to open your eyes as he opened Peter's. And if you are ready to bow with Thomas, then come to him as he invited everyone to come: "Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest… for I am gentle and lowly in heart" (Matt. 11:28–29). Turn from your sin, and trust him as your Savior, Christ, and Lord.

Living It: Six Practices for This Week

1. **Read a Gospel.** Start reading the Gospel of Mark, a chapter a day. It is the shortest, and you can finish it in sixteen days.

2. **Watch what he does.** As you read, keep a list: every time Jesus does something only God can do, write it down.

3. **Watch how human he is.** Notice how often Jesus is tired, hungry, moved, or weeping. Thank him that he knows what it is to be human.

4. **Pray the I AM sayings.** Pick one each day (bread, light, door, shepherd, resurrection, way, vine) and pray it back to him.

5. **Answer the question.** Write one honest paragraph: who do you say Jesus is? Share it with someone in your group.

6. **Memorize John 1:14.** "And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory, glory as of the only Son from the Father, full of grace and truth."

Before Lesson 20: *Read Mark 1 and Matthew 5–7. Lesson 20 looks at the kingdom of God that Jesus announced and the upside-down life he called his followers to.*

For Discussion

1. The whole story has been heading toward Jesus. Which earlier promise in this series means the most to you now that you see him?
2. John says the Word "became flesh." What does it tell you about God that he came himself rather than sending a message?
3. The disciples were more afraid after the storm was calmed than during it. Why?
4. Which of Jesus' claims or actions strikes you as the strongest evidence that he is God?
5. Jesus got tired, hungry, and wept. How does his full humanity change the way you pray to him?
6. Many people say Jesus was a good teacher and nothing more. How would you answer them from this lesson?

7. Jesus asked, “Who do you say that I am?” What is your answer today?

Sources & For Further Study

- On the person of Christ: Westminster Confession of Faith 8.2; the Definition of Chalcedon (AD 451); Donald Macleod, *The Person of Christ*.
- On the date of Jesus’ birth: Harold W. Hoehner, *Chronological Aspects of the Life of Christ*. On John’s Gospel: D. A. Carson, *The Gospel According to John* (Pillar).
- For further reading: Sinclair B. Ferguson, *In Christ Alone*; Timothy Keller, *Hidden Christmas*; B. B. Warfield, *The Person and Work of Christ*.



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